

Enhancing Socio-Emotional Functioning of Adults with Disabilities: Evaluation of an Experiential Intervention in a Day Care Facility

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Abstract—The socio-emotional functioning of adults with disabilities constitutes a critical factor for their quality of life, autonomy, and meaningful social inclusion. In recent years, international literature has highlighted the importance of interventions that enhance skills such as emotion recognition and regulation, empathy, cooperation, and group participation, within the framework of Social and Emotional Learning (SEL) and emotional intelligence [?], [?], [?]. However, studies focusing on adults with disabilities in Day Care Center (DCC) settings remain limited.

The aim of the present study is to evaluate the effectiveness of a holistic, experiential program of socio-emotional empowerment for adult beneficiaries with intellectual and psychosocial difficulties in a day care facility. The evaluation was conducted longitudinally across three phases: before the intervention, during the intervention, and after its completion. Three sources of information were used: beneficiary self-reports, trainer/educator observations, and assessments by an independent observer.

Thirty adult program beneficiaries, two trainers/educators, and one independent observer participated in the study. The analysis was conducted on complete observation pairs. Socio-emotional functioning was assessed through a structured Likert-scale instrument covering core indicators such as emotion recognition and expression, self-regulation, cooperation, group integration, and acceptance of self and others. Statistical analysis included paired-sample tests [?] comparing Phase A and Phase C scores for each evaluator category, as well as effect-size estimation using Cohen's d [?].

Results showed significant and substantial improvement in beneficiaries' socio-emotional functioning across all evaluation sources. Mean self-report scores increased from 3.24 in Phase A to 4.75 in Phase C ($p < .001$, $d = 2.45$), while trainer/educator questionnaires recorded a corresponding improvement from 2.84 to 3.49 ($p < .001$, $d = 1.17$). The independent observer's assessments confirmed the positive change, with mean scores increasing from 2.18 to 2.60 ($p < .001$, $d = 1.63$). Longitudinal analysis revealed steady and continuous improvement from Phase A to Phase C across all evaluator categories.

The findings indicate that a systematically designed experiential program within a DCC framework may function as a significant tool for empowering the socio-emotional functioning of adults with disabilities, enhancing their inclusion, participation, and psychosocial well-being. The study contributes to the international literature by offering a documented and replicable intervention and evaluation model adapted to adult day care facilities for persons with disabilities.

Index Terms—Social-emotional learning, emotional intelligence, adults with disabilities, day care centers, group interventions, social inclusion, program evaluation.

II. RELATED LITERATURE

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III. METHODOLOGY

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IV. RESULTS

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V. DISCUSSION

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VI. CONCLUSION

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I. INTRODUCTION

Write your introduction here.